PEARSON EDEXCEL GCSE (9–1) HISTORY MARK SCHEME

Best Guess Mock Exam 11: Limitations of Civil Rights Progress (1965–75)

Paper 3: Conflict at Home and Abroad: the USA, 1954–75 (1HI0/33)

Question 1: Inference from Source A (4 Marks)

Target: AO3 (4 marks). Award 1 mark for each valid inference, up to 2. Award 1 mark for each corresponding quote/detail, up to 2.

Sample Acceptable Inferences (racial divisions and inequalities in American cities in 1968):

• **Inference 1:** American society was becoming increasingly polarized into racially divided and unequal communities.

- *Detail from source:* "Our nation is moving toward two societies, one black, one white—separate and unequal. Discrimination and segregation have long permeated much of American life..."

• **Inference 2:** Entrenched racial discrimination posed an existential threat to American democratic stability.

- *Detail from source:* "To pursue our present course will involve the continuing polarization of the American community and, ultimately, the destruction of basic democratic values."

Question 2: Causal Explanation (12 Marks)

Target: AO1/AO2 (12 marks). Level 4 (10–12 marks): An analytical explanation showing a line of reasoning with clear links to the outcome, supported by accurate, detailed knowledge.

"One reason why the civil rights movement faced growing limitations in the years 1965–75 was the shift in focus to deep-seated economic and housing inequalities in Northern cities, which faced intense white resistance." In 1966, Martin Luther King Jr. launched the **Chicago Freedom Movement** to combat housing discrimination. However, when activists marched through white neighborhoods like Cicero, they were met by violent white mobs throwing bricks and bottles, and Mayor Richard Daley reneged on agreements once King left the city. *Therefore, this Northern backlash delayed progress because it proved that informal, de facto segregation and entrenched white racism in the North were much harder to dismantle than Southern de jure segregation, leaving ghetto conditions unchanged.*

"A second reason why the civil rights movement struggled to achieve progress was the findings and subsequent neglect of the **Kerner Commission** in 1968." Appointed by President Johnson to investigate the causes of urban riots, the commission concluded that the primary cause of violence was systemic white racism, warning that America was split into "two societies, one Black, one white - separate and unequal." Although the report recommended massive federal investment in housing, jobs, and education to rebuild inner-city communities, Johnson largely rejected the findings due to the soaring cost of the Vietnam War and political backlash. *Therefore, the government's failure to act on these findings delayed progress because it left the root economic causes of Black frustration unresolved, leading to persistent poverty and inequality in urban areas.*

"A third reason why progress became limited after 1965 was the fragmentation of the civil rights coalition following the assassination of Martin Luther King Jr." The assassination of King in Memphis in **1968** triggered riots in over 100 cities, demonstrating the deep anger of Black Americans but also alienating white moderates who feared urban violence. SCLC's subsequent initiatives, such as the **Poor People's Campaign**, failed to secure federal reforms due to leadership struggles under Ralph Abernathy and the rise of radical groups like the Black Panthers. *Therefore, the loss of unified, non-violent leadership and the splintering of the movement delayed progress because it destroyed the broad political coalition needed to pass further major federal civil rights legislation.*

Question 3(a): Source Utility (8 Marks)

Target: AO3 (8 marks). Assess content utility, verify with contextual knowledge, and evaluate provenance reliability and limitations for BOTH sources.

Source B is highly useful for demonstrating the local, grassroots reality and limitations of the Fair Housing Act of 1968. The activist explains that despite the law, real estate agents used "redlining", banks denied mortgages, and school boards gerrymandered zones, leaving suburbs white and Black families trapped in underfunded ghettos by 1975. This utility is supported by my knowledge that the Fair Housing Act was difficult to enforce because it relied on individuals filing lawsuits to prove discrimination, allowing practices like redlining and de facto housing segregation to persist, which confirms the source's claims about the limits of legislation. The provenance of a memoir by a civil rights activist published in 1980 increases its usefulness because it provides a reflective, first-hand account of the disappointment felt by activists who saw legal victories fail to translate into social and economic equality. Although it represents a personal and disappointed viewpoint, it accurately reflects the structural barriers that remained in Northern cities.

Source C is highly useful for understanding the official government perspective on the progress and difficulties in enforcing civil rights laws. The report highlights legal and political achievements, such as a "fivefold increase in Black elected officials in the South", but admits to "severe challenges in enforcing the Fair Housing Act" and local resistance to "busing for school integration", showing that de facto segregation was resistant to legal action. This is supported by my knowledge that school busing programs—such as those in Boston in 1974—provoked violent protests by white residents who opposed federal court integration orders, demonstrating the intense local resistance to integration. The provenance of an official Department of Justice report in 1974 makes it highly useful as a reliable source of statistical progress and legal enforcement records. While it is an official government document that may seek to present federal efforts in a positive light, its candid admission of failure to enforce housing laws and integration makes it a very credible record of the limits of federal power.

Question 3(b): Difference Between Interpretations (4 Marks)

Target: AO4 (4 marks). Identify the main difference of view, supported by details from both interpretations.

The main difference is that Interpretation 1 argues that by 1975, the civil rights movement had **"failed to conquer the economic division of the nation"** and did little to improve the lives of the urban poor. In contrast, Interpretation 2 argues that the progress made by 1975 was **"substantial and irreversible"**, emphasizing significant achievements in political representation, voting rights, and affirmative action.

Question 3(c): Reason for Difference in Interpretations (4 Marks)

Target: AO4 (4 marks). Explain how the historians may have relied on different sources to reach their views.

The interpretations differ because the historians have given weight to different sources. Interpretation 1 is supported by Source B, which details how "suburbs remained almost entirely white", leading to the view that the movement **"did little to improve the lives of the urban poor"**. Conversely, Interpretation 2 is supported by Source C, which highlights how the Voting Rights Act resulted in a "fivefold increase in Black elected officials", leading to the view that the progress made was **"substantial and irreversible"**.

Question 3(d): Evaluation of Interpretation (16 Marks + 4 SPaG)

Target: AO4 (16 marks) + SPaG (4 marks). Level 4 (13–16 marks): Balanced discussion analyzing both interpretations with sustained contextual knowledge, leading to a justified judgment.

I agree to a large extent with Interpretation 1 that the civil rights movement faced severe limitations and failed to bridge the economic divide by 1975. Despite the passage of the Fair Housing Act, de facto segregation remained the norm in Northern cities. As Source B details, real estate agents used **redlining** and banks refused mortgages to keep the suburbs white. MLK's **Chicago Freedom Movement** of 1966 failed to achieve its housing integration goals due to intense white backlash in suburbs like **Cicero** and political obstruction by Mayor Daley. Furthermore, the **Kerner Commission**'s 1968 warning that America was splitting into **two societies, separate and unequal** was ignored, as President Johnson refused to fund its recommended urban welfare programs due to the costs of the **Vietnam War**. Consequently, by 1975, Black youth unemployment remained extremely high, proving Interpretation 1's view that legal gains **"did little to improve the lives of the urban poor"** and failed to resolve **"economic division"**.

However, Interpretation 2 is also valid in emphasizing that the political and social status of Black Americans was permanently transformed. The Voting Rights Act of 1965 enabled millions of Black citizens to vote, leading to a massive increase in Black political representation. By 1974, as shown in Source C, there was a **fivefold increase in Black elected officials**, including the election of Black mayors in major cities like Detroit and Atlanta. Furthermore, **affirmative action** policies introduced under Johnson and Nixon opened up opportunities in higher education and white-collar employment, helping to grow a Black middle class. Thus, while economic equality was not fully realized, the gains in democratic rights and representation were, as Interpretation 2 states, **"substantial and irreversible"** and ended de facto segregation.

Overall, Interpretation 1 is more convincing. While the civil rights movement successfully dismantled de jure segregation in the South and created a new class of Black political leaders (Interpretation 2), the structural economic inequalities of the ghettos remained entrenched. The persistence of housing redlining, de facto school segregation, and high poverty rates meant that by 1975, the daily reality for the majority of working-class Black Americans was still one of segregation and economic neglect.